Arvind Kejriwal was sworn in as Delhi's chief minister on 28 December before a rapturous crowd at the Ramlila Maidan. He spoke with great passion, as always. 'If 1.5 crore Delhiites can get together, we can root out corruption. Let us swear we will never take or receive a bribe.' He even sang songs that had the audience cheering him along. For those few hours at least, it appeared that Narendra Modi was not the only magnetic politician who could connect with the masses. He now had real competition. But Kejriwal would soon learn that there is a big difference between being a populist streetfighter and occupying a seat of responsibility.

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From a newsman's perspective, there is only one word to describe the forty-nine days Kejriwal was in power in Delhi—chaotic. Not a single day passed without Kejriwal or some member of the AAP party giving us a news break. For a while it seemed that tracking Kejriwal had become a media obsession. In one of our Sunday phone conversations, Modi seemed to lose his poise, *'Tumhare Dilli media ko Kejriwal ke aage kuch dikhta hai ya nahi. Baaki chief ministers ko tum nahi dikhate aur Kejriwal ko tumne national leader bana diya!'* (Your Delhi media does not seem to see anything beyond Kejriwal.

You don't show any other chief minister and you have made Kejriwal a national leader). Clearly, in the run-up to the general elections, the AAP leader was getting under the skin of his bigger rivals.

Modi, though, had a point. My defence was the 'tyranny of distance'. The phrase comes from the landmark Australian book (with the same title) by historian Geoffrey Blainey which argued how Australia's geographical remoteness had shaped its history. Geographical proximities, sadly, define news priorities in the so-called 'national' Indian media. Since Kejriwal was operating in and around Delhi within a few kilometres of most TV studio headquarters (Noida near Delhi has the highest media density in India), he was easily accessible. It was so much easier to park an OB van outside the Delhi secretariat than in the heart of Bastar or Kokrajhar.